

ADVENTURE IN THE CLOUDS

After defeating Rothex the Red and arriving at the cloud castle of "Sky-Hammer", the group believes that they will have time to rest. Unfortunately this is not so, for upon arriving at the cloud giant's stronghold, they are met by a company of cloud giant warriors, who escort them to see king "Torgon Skywrath". King Torgon is not an evil giant and is more than willing to listen to the group's explanation on how they were able to activate and use the "Giant's Arch" magical gateway. After the group explains to him what happened and how they killed the evil red dragon Rothex, than most likely Torgon will except them as friends and invite them to stay at his castle home.

During their stay, they will find out many things about the cloud giant's and their way of life. However the group will notice that there seem's to be a lingering melancholy about the castle and around the residents. If the group inquires about the reason why most of the giants are saddened, they find out that the king's daughter, "Skielara", has been missing for over three week's. Although Skielara was not a child giantess, she was not a full grown warrior either. Skielara was prone to bout's of exploration and adventure and it was during one of these sojourns that she ran into a cloud giant that called himself "Hagan". Unbeknownst to Skielara, Hagan was not a cloud giant at all, but an evil human sorcerer in disguise. Hagan, over several week's, managed to charm and eventually seduce Skielara into doing almost whatever he desired. Eventually Hagan convinced Skielara to take him to her father's personal chambers where Hagan hoped to find the ancient giant artifact known as "The Rod of Crafting". Built by ancient giant wizards and shaman's age's ago, the rod was said to be the way that cloud giants created their floating cities and fortresses. Hagan hoped that with the rod in his possession, that he would be able to craft many floating fortresses and eventually create an army with which to conquer the known north. Fortunately for Skielara, the cloud giant shaman known as "Cloud Walker", suspected that Hagan was not all he appeared to be and arrived in time to stop Hagan from stealing the Rod of Crafting. Unfortunately, he could not prevent Hagan, now exposed as an evil human sorcerer, from kidnapping Skielara and escaping to his sorcerous lair.

Although King Torgon is grief stricken and shaken by the loss of his daughter, he is still king first and must think about all his people's safety. Cloud Walker has used his shamanistic magic to determine where Hagan has taken princess Skielara, but cannot determine anymore than that due to the powerful magical wards that Hagan employ's. Although many cloud giant's have volunteered to try and rescue the princess, King Torgon has refused stating that they don't know enough of the world of men and Hagan's magic is very powerful. Better to lose a daughter than more of his people to the evil sorcerers spells. Cloud Walker may hint at it, but it should not be necessary to convince the group to head to Hagan's lair and find and rescue the princess. If the group states their determination to help King Torgon by rescuing his daughter, than he will offer the group whatever they want as reward for the safe return of his daughter.

After agreeing to rescue the king's daughter, Cloud Walker provides the group a gift of friendship. He had used his shamanistic cloud magic to summon the groups griffons, that had been flying about the Nether mountain range. Now that the group has a way to leave the cloud giant's home they should be on their way. Cloud Walker give's the group one more final gift, he call's it the "Pearl of Travel". Should the group get past Hagan's spell wards and find Skielara, all they have to do is smash the pearl and a means of travel will appear to take Skielara back home to Skyhammer Castle.

Once the group determines that they are somewhere above the Spine of the World mountain range, a celestial cloud hawk will appear and guide the group to the easterly most part of the Lurkwood forest, near the fell pass. After a day of travelling, the group will see an ancient stone fortress set against the side of the largest mountain nearby. Once they land and find a place to rest, they will have one day to prepare and rest before a patrol out of Hagan's fortress will accidentally happen upon their resting place.

The group can search for a way into the fortress and will find several wall's with breaches in them, and the main gate is in disarray's. However each of the breach's in the wall's defenses is guarded by heavily armed and armored orcs. Also, with careful observing, the group can occasionally see giant sized figures walking about the fortress, although the type is too difficult to determine due to the distance. Hagan's spell

wards prevent any type of aerial assault upon the fortress, but after several hours worth of searching, the group will find an old sewage drain or cistern on the far side of the fortress, that has been covered up with brambles and tumbleweed's. If the group decides to use this means of entrance, they will find that they will have very few encounters, except for a mated pair of Otyugh that have claimed the sewers under the fortress as their home. If the group moves quickly enough, they will be able to save a young stone giant named "Shale" from being food for the Otyugh's and possibly gain an ally. If the group succeeds in saving shale, then he will tell them of Hagan's dark plans.

Hagan is a human sorcerer of great evil, who plans to rule the entire north as Overking. Hagan has made many allies among the orcish clans of the Spine of the World mountains. Hagan has also made many friends among the giant clans around the north, mainly the Fire giant's, Frost giants, Hill giants and Stone giants. Hagan had long sought an alliance with the Cloud giant's, to gain their ability to create floating fortresses, so that he would have a way to transport his armies across the north. However due to his lack of patience and his discovery by King Torgon, the magical ability that he seeks is now lost to him. However Hagan believes that by holding King Torgon's daughter hostage, that he will eventually give him the Rod of Crafting and be able to create his army of floating castles. Hagan has been telling the Giant Lords that he wished to bring forth a great giant empire, such as the old days, with Hagan as the ruler of all humans.

Shale believed that Hagan's plan was wrong and spoke to Hagan of going back to tell his people not to ally with Hagan. Hagan, in a fit of rage, hurled sorcerous magic at Shale and wounded him almost unto death. Then Hagan had his orc minions throw Shale into the sewer to either die slowly, or be eaten by the creatures that inhabit the depths. Shale believes that by killing Hagan, the entire alliance will fall apart and an invasion of the northern lands will be averted. Although Shale does not know where Hagan is keeping Skielara, he does know that she is not in the dungeons. Shale was dragged through the dungeons, on his way to be dumped into the sewers and did not see any giantess among the prisoners. He did see several men, elves, and possibly dwarves imprisoned there, though. Shale thanks the group for helping to free him and gives them a smooth granite stone with a giantish rune etched into the stone. Shale tells you that you are an ally of him and his tribe and if ever you find yourself meeting any of his kin, just show them the stone and they will be friendly to you. So saying, Shale departs the sewers and heads out into the mountains to find his way home.

The group should then head up into the lower dungeons where they find several Orog jailers along with a Ogre warden. Hopefully the group can dispatch the creatures without making too much noise and free the prisoners. The prisoners consist of three humans, two elves, four dwarves, and one gnome. All are weak from mistreatment or lack of nourishment and a few are on the verge of death due to prior injuries. If the group frees the prisoners and heals their wounds, they will find that they have made new allies. Although having extra sword-arms would be good to have around, most of the freed prisoners only wish to return to their homes and families. If the group gives the prisoners food, supplies and perhaps some weapons, then the prisoners will be eternally grateful and will have made allies for the future.

Once the group starts moving into the upper levels, they will start running into different groups of Hagan's alliance. Most are bands of orcs or orogs patrolling the fortress, however they should have a run-in with a couple of giants while moving about the upper levels. Eventually they will come upon a great meeting hall where Hagan, along with all the giant lords, are feasting and talking of plans to conquer the north. Seated next to Hagan, bound with chains and magically shape changed to human size, is Skielara. The group must figure a way to free Skielara and escape before Hagan and his allies hunt them down. If the group has patience and they wait a few minutes, they will see Hagan end the feast and bid good night to his giant allies. After everyone leaves, only Hagan and Skielara remain in the great feast hall. Hagan amuses himself by making Skielara play at serving wench and having her clean up the table leftovers. If the group works together and strikes swiftly, they may be able to hurt Hagan or perhaps kill him, before he alerts his giant allies. If the group does not finish the battle within six rounds, then Hagan's allies will come to the great feast hall to see what all the commotion is about.

If the group manages to kill Hagan and free Skielara, then they should be able to flee on griffon back. However, if they find themselves trapped and decide to use the Pearl of Travel, they will find that nothing happens immediately. What the group does not know is that the Pearl of Travel will not take

Skielara to Skyhammer Castle, but will instead bring Skyhammer Castle to her. If the group manages to hold out long enough, they will begin to hear the sounds of battle outside the fortress wall's. If they manage to find an open window, they see Skyhammer Castle floating above Hagan's fortress, dropping huge boulders down upon the defenders. They will also see King Targon leading several cloud giants on an assault on the fortress. Eventually, when it is learned that Hagan is dead, the defenders of the fortress will surrender or flee into the surrounding mountains, leaving the cloud giants victorious.

Once Hagan is dead, the spell that had altered Skielara will eventually fade and she will revert back to her normal size. King Targon will give his eternal thanks and gratitude the the adventures and let them know that any reward, that is within his power, he will grant. Hopefully the group merely ask's for King Targon's friendship, in which case Targon will be even more impressed with the group, and give them a friendship crystal. King Targon tell's them that if they are ever in trouble, or need his clan's help, then all they have to do is smash the crystal and they will come. So saying, the adventures should head back to their home's in Silverymoon for a much needed rest.

Adventure Background Information:

Hagan- Human Sorcerer, 13th level, Lawful Evil, Hp's-38,

Trasher Man-Slaughter- Hill Giant male, Chaotic Evil, Hp's-134

Jarl Vergold- Frost Giant male, Chaotic Evil, Hp- 155

Chief Bergutin Black Burner, Fire Giant male, Chaotic Evil, hp-165

Rocklord Sar'tol- Stone Giant male, Neutral Evil, hp- 147

Aster Horlogis- Fog Giant male, Neutral Evil, hp-149

Prisoners held under Hagan's Fortress:

- 1) Sgt. Brayton, human male soldier of Nesme, 3rd level warrior
- 2) Private Cole, human male soldier of Nesme, 1st level warrior
- 3) Private Derrick, human male soldier of Nesme, 1st level warrior
- 4) Axecleaver Mogor, dwarf male warleader of clan Axecleaver, 4th level dwarven warrior
- 5) Herod, dwarf male of clan Axecleaver, 1st level dwarven warrior
- 6) Heisa, dwarf female of clan Axecleaver, 1st level dwarven warrior
- 7) Lortol, dwarf male of clan Axecleaver, 1st level dwarven warrior
- 8) Belira Morningdance, gold elf female of the Morningdance family holdings in the Lurkwood, 2/2 elven warrior/priest
- 9) Hasperen Leafwalker, gold elf male, 3rd level druid of the Lurkwood forest
- 10) Berol Glittergem, wood gnome male, 2nd level ranger of the Lurkwood forest